

1.1 The Generations of Mobile Telephony

Humble Beginnings—The “Zeroth” Generation (0G)

In the beginning, there was radio. “Remarkable concept!” they called it. And what a concept it was! You could talk to people long distances away without the physical connection of a wire, and if you had the necessary machinery to haul around the 40-odd kilos of equipment, it was even mobile.

Then there was the telephone. Alexander Graham Bell’s invention that let you talk to anyone who was connected to a network called the telephone exchange. You called the exchange, told the friendly voice at the other end who you wanted to connect to. A few plugs switched and soon you were having a happy little chat with your friend.

And then there were the wizards who realised that a combination of these two technologies could lead to the birth of an even more powerful concept. A ‘breaking’ concept, if you will. Two things led them to think along these lines.

Firstly, the popularity of radio—everybody wanted to be a part of it. There was HAM radio, operated by amateurs who loved to tinker with all things electronic. The growth of HAM radio led to the



Steve Roberts (aka N4RVE), a famous mobileer, with his Behemoth